

Mangrove A type of tree that grows in tidal water in the tropics, or a forest of these trees.

Mantle The thick layer of very hot, but not molten, rock beneath the Earth's crust.

Mantle plume A rising current of heat within the Earth's mantle.

Maritime climate A climate that is strongly influenced by a nearby ocean. It has cool summers and mild winters, and regular rain.

Meltwater Water that flows off melting ice.

Methane A gas formed from carbon and hydrogen, that is both a fossil fuel (natural gas) and a potent greenhouse gas.

Microbe A microscopic living thing.

Midocean ridge A ridge of submarine mountains on the ocean floor, created by a spreading rift between two plates of the Earth's crust.

Migration A regular journey by an animal, often seasonal, made to exploit temporary food resources or good breeding conditions.

Minerals The natural materials that make up rocks. They are carried in ocean water, and many are used as nutrients by oceanic phytoplankton.

Molecule The smallest particle of a substance such as a gas or liquid, formed from atoms of the elements that make up that substance. A water molecule, for example, contains two hydrogen atoms and one oxygen atom.

Mollusk A soft-bodied animal that may have a shell, such as a snail or a clam. An octopus is an advanced type of mollusk.

Monsoon A seasonal wind change that alters the weather pattern, especially in southern Asia.

Neap tide A twice-monthly tide with a small tidal range between high and low water.

Nutrients Substances that living things need to build their tissues.

Ocean trench A deep chasm in the ocean floor created by one plate of the Earth's crust being dragged beneath another.

Oceanic crust The relatively thin crust of solid basalt that lies above the Earth's mantle and forms the bedrock of the ocean floor.

Organism A living thing.

Parasite An organism that feeds off other live organisms.

Photophore A living organ that produces light.

Photosynthesis The process by which green plants and some other organisms use the energy of light to make carbohydrate food (sugar) from carbon dioxide and water.

Phytoplankton Microscopic organisms that drift near the ocean surface and make food by photosynthesis.

Pillow lava Pillow-shaped lumps of volcanic rock, usually basalt, formed by lava erupting from the ocean floor and solidifying in the cold water.

Plankton Living things that mainly drift in the water, rather than swimming actively.

Plankton bloom An increase in the amount of plankton in water, caused by the organisms multiplying rapidly.

Predator An animal that preys upon other live animals, attacking and eating them.

Prevailing wind A wind that blows from a particular direction most of the time.

Protein A complex substance that a living thing makes out of simpler nutrients and uses to form its tissues.

Protozoan A very simple type of animal, usually microscopic.

Reef A ridge of submerged rock, often created by marine animals called corals.

Rift A break in the Earth's crust caused by the rocks moving apart.

ROV A remotely operated vehicle or nonmanned submersible.

Salt marsh A marshy area fringing a tidal zone such as a river estuary.

Scavenger An animal that eats the remains of dead animals.

Scuba An air-supply system used by divers. The word SCUBA stands for Self-Contained Underwater Breathing Apparatus.

Seamount An ocean-floor volcano that does not break the ocean surface to form an island.

Sediment Solid particles such as sand, silt, or mud that have settled on the seabed or elsewhere. They may harden to form sedimentary rock.

Silica A compound of silicon and oxygen that forms the mineral quartz, the main ingredient of sand, and is used to make glass.

Sonar A system that uses pulses of sound waves to detect solid objects.

Sounding Finding the depth of water.

Spawn To release eggs into the water, where they may be fertilized. Most fish reproduce like this.

Spring tide A twice-monthly tide with a large tidal range between high and low water.

Storm surge A local, temporary rise in sea level caused by storm winds and low air pressure.

Strait A narrow stretch of water between two coasts.

Subduction zone A boundary between two plates of the Earth's crust, where one plate plunges beneath the other and is destroyed.

Submarine fan A fan-shaped area of sediment on the seafloor, formed by river water flowing into the sea.

Submersible A craft designed to dive to the ocean depths.

Sunlit zone The region of the ocean near the surface, with enough sunlight for phytoplankton and seaweeds to make food and grow.

Supercontinent A large landmass formed by several continents becoming joined together.

Superheated Heated above the normal boiling point at which a liquid would turn into a gas under conditions of high pressure.

Swell A regular wave pattern.

Temperate Neither tropical nor polar.

Thermocline The boundary between deep, cold, dense water and a layer of warmer, less dense water that floats at the surface.

Thermohaline circulation A global flow of ocean currents, driven by variations in water density caused by differences of temperature and salt content.

Tidal race A fast-moving tidal stream that has chaotic waves and whirlpools.

Tidal range The difference between high and low tide level.

Tidal stream A horizontal flow of water created by the rise and fall of the tide.

Trade winds Steady winds that blow from the east in the tropical oceans.

Transform boundary A boundary between two plates of the Earth's crust, where one plate is sliding against the other.

Tsunami A destructive sea wave usually produced by an earthquake, but which can also be caused by submarine landslides or volcanic eruptions.

Turbidity current An underwater flow of water loaded with mud and other sediments, resembling a river in flood.

Twilight zone The deep region of the ocean where only faint blue light penetrates from the surface.

Upwelling zone A part of the ocean where deep water that is rich in plant nutrients is drawn up to the surface.

Water vapor The gas formed when liquid water is warmed and evaporates.

Wavelength Distance between two wave crests.

Zooplankton The community of mostly small animals that drift and swim in the ocean, mainly near the surface.

Zooxanthellae Microscopic organisms that live in the tissues of coral and other marine animals, and make food by photosynthesis.